



UNIVERSITÀ
DEGLI STUDI DELLA
TUSCIA

CoARA Action Plan

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Università degli Studi della Tuscia

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Introduction

CoARA – Coalition on Advancing Research Assessment

University of Tuscia (UNITUS) is part of CoARA, together with 683 research organisations based in Europe.

The mission of CoARA is to enable systemic reform of research assessment, based on common principles within an agreed timeframe, and to facilitate exchanges of information and mutual learning between all those willing to improve research assessment practices.

In May 2023, UNITUS signed the CoARA agreement which establishes a common direction for research assessment reform, while respecting organisations' autonomy. The Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment is based on 10 commitments, and it sets a shared direction for changes in assessment practices for research, researchers and research performing organisations, with the overarching goal to maximise the quality and impact of research.

The Agreement includes the principles, commitments and timeframe for reforms and lays out the principles for a Coalition of organisations willing to work together in implementing the changes.

The commitment of University of Tuscia to CoARA

In 2023 UNITUS joined the CoARA Italian National Chapter, led by CNR and the University of Bologna, aimed at assisting the Italian CoARA members in implementing the commitments.

In the context of the Italian National Chapter UNITUS is participating to several activities, such as the translation of the CoARA agreement in Italian (the document is available on Zenodo at this [link](#)), and the expansion of the National Chapter.

UNITUS is also committed to produce an Institutional Action Plan, aligning with the other research entities which are members of CoARA in Italy, and promoting change in the practices of research assessment.

The goal of this document is to **ensure that UNITUS research assessment practices align with the CoARA** commitments, thus supporting a diverse and inclusive research environment.

Core commitments of CoARA Agreement

“Our vision is that the assessment of research, researchers and research organisations recognizes the diverse outputs, practices and activities that maximise the quality and impact of research” [CoARA Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment, 2022]

The core commitments of CoARA agreement, that are detailed in the document, can be listed as follows:

- C1:** Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research
- C2:** Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators
- C3:** Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics
- C4:** Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment
- C5:** Commit resources to reforming research assessment
- C6:** Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes
- C7:** Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use
- C8:** Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition
- C9:** Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments
- C10:** Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence [...], and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

UNITUS Action Plan

The following actions are in progress or planned to ensure the implementation of the CoARA commitments at UNITUS. For each action, the related CoARA commitment is specified. Details about the status of implementation, and link/reference to supporting documents are also provided in the table.

Objective	Action	Ref. CoARA Comm.	Status and timeframe	Links / reference documents
Dedicate specific support to favour the application for funding opportunities dedicated to early-stage career researchers	Attract and train young talented researchers to apply for national, European, and international research programs with UNITUS as the host institution, capable of offering the best informational and operational tools.	C1 + C5 + C8	Ongoing (since 2022)	Talent valorisation and attraction LINK
Reward researchers who apply to international competitive calls for proposals even though not funded, but evaluated as excellent	UnitusTalent involves the publication of a call for expressions of interest aimed at researchers and professors engaged in international research operating in Italy and abroad, who are interested in submitting projects within the MSCA, ERC, and Rita Levi Montalcini calls with UNITUS as the host institution for their research activities.	C1 + C5	Ongoing (since 2022)	UnitusTalent LINK
Dedicate specific budget to promote the cooperation between actors beyond academia	The Third Mission integrates and expands upon the traditional activities of the university (research and teaching) by promoting social impact. The Third Mission includes a set of activities aimed at strengthening the relationships between the academic world and the community, schools, institutions, and businesses, with the goal of promoting the social, economic, and cultural growth of the territory.	C1 + C5 + C8	Ongoing (since 2022)	Third mission initiatives LINK Call for funding third mission activities

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Reward early-career researchers' impacts	Incentivise high-quality scientific publications where the first author is an early-career researcher (assistant professor)	C1 + C5	Ongoing (2025)	VQR 2020-2024 - Avviso programma di incentivi per Ricercatori a tempo determinato per la promozione di prodotti della ricerca di qualità
Promote research diversity recognition by supporting internationalization and Erasmus+ Staff mobilities	Erasmus+ international mobilities: Staff Mobility for Teaching and Staff Mobility for Training – STT. UNITUS is part of the Euro League of Life Science, a network that consists of 12 European member universities and 2 non-European partner universities	C1 + C7 + C8	Ongoing	Erasmus+ staff mobility UNITUS joined ELLS in 2024 Reserved places for foreign students in PhD calls LINK
Promote Open Science practices and open access publications	Incentives available to professors and researchers of UNITUS to publish Open Access, by signing agreements with publishers (Free gold open access with Elsevier and Wiley, 10% discount on MDPI)	C1 + C7	Ongoing (since 2023)	Incentives for publishing Open Access
Implement the Institutional Research Repository public landing page	Implementation of D-SPACE, the institutional research repository of UNITUS	C6	Ongoing (since 2021)	D-SPACE
Continuous improvement of research assessment criteria, tools and processes	Development of review criteria in the context of the periodical monitoring of research outputs	C6	Ongoing (since 2021)	Relazione sui risultati dell'attività di ricerca, di formazione alla ricerca e di trasferimento tecnologico 2023

Objective	Action	Ref. CoARA Comm.	Status and timeframe	Links / reference documents
Raising awareness about funding opportunities for early-career researchers through the organization of specific events	Seminars about MSCA, ERC, Rita Levi Montalcini, Invest your Talent in Italy, and StudyInItaly funding opportunities to help early-career researchers organising their application	C7	Ongoing (since 2022)	Talent valorisation and attraction LINK
Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide communication about the actions implemented by UNITUS	Organisation of seminars and events on research assessment evaluation, the principles of CoARA agreement, the distorting effects of entirely quantitative evaluation, unbiased and equitable peer-review	C7 + C9	Planned (2025)	Program to be issued in 2025
Promote quality recruitment of early-career researchers (PhD and post-doc)	Development of guidelines that define criteria for responsible research assessment, to be shared with the judging commissions of PhD and post-doc positions	C2 + C6	Planned (2026)	Guidelines to be issued by the end of 2025, to be used for calls in 2026
Promote the recognition of diverse careers during the evaluation of applicants to UNITUS research positions (including PhD)	Provide guidelines and templates for narrative CVs in the call for applications to UNITUS positions	C1 + C6	Planned (2026)	Flexible template for narrative CVs to be included in calls for applications issued in 2026
Communicate progress made on the implementation of the CoARA Action Plan	Inclusion of a section monitoring the advancement of the CoARA Action Plan in the annual UNITUS research report	C9	Planned (2025)	New section to be included in the annual UNITUS Report on the results of research of the year 2024, which will be published by the end of 2025